ly to see and measure *Chamkila* against *Rockstar*, also centred on a musician, albeit a fictional one. Unlike that hit film starring Ranbir Kapoor, this one will release straight on streaming. "Netflix took it so lovingly, it was impossible to refuse," says Ali. The filmmaker assures that he has made it "even more cinematic" after he knew it would be an OTT release.

It certainly didn't deter A.R. Rahman from collaborating with Ali for the fourth time—after *Highway*, *Rockstar* and *Tamasha*. In interviews, the Oscar-winning composer has said that Ali has reinvented himself. The assessment comes from the choices Ali made as he shot the tale in real locations in Punjab, including the assassination sequence at the actual location. The film takes sync sound to the next level with on-location recording of 13 songs from Chamkila's vast discography sung by Dosanjh and Chopra live with musicians accompanying them. "You get the real feel of being in an *akhada* [live music performances in rural villages in Punjabi parlance]; you hear the crowd cheering," he says. "It was an experiment on how to record it nicely." Dosanjh, already a beloved singer with international acclaim and, more significantly, a member of the Chamkila fan club himself, learned to play the *tumbi*, a folk instrument synonymous with Chamkila, while Chopra took diction classes to sing in the dialect.

With *Chamkila*, Ali also incorporated A. R. Rahman's suggestion to give the 'music biopic' a Broadway treatment by deploying musical theatre. In *Chamkila*, it sees Rahman compose six songs that enlighten viewers about the titular character by seeing him through the eyes and opinions of locals. For them, the artist offered "relief from the drudgery and darkness of their own lives," says Ali. The very music that catapulted him to stardom would ultimately be the reason for his death. ■

–Suhani Singh

CINEMA

BREAKING THE MOULD

ACTOR **GULSHAN DEVAIAH** IS LOOKING FORWARD TO *LITTLE THOMAS*, A SLICE-OF-LIFE FILM THAT TAKES HIM AWAY FROM THE DARK CHARACTERS HE HAS BEEN PLAYING

There's never a dull moment when actor Gulshan Devaiah speaks his heart out, whether it's on- or off-screen. From the beginning of his career, he has never shied away from taking on layered roles—be it in *Shaitan*, *Hunterrr*, *Badhaai Do*, *Duranga*, or *Guns & Gulaabs*.

However, after a string of 'dark' characters, he is relieved to play Desmond in an upcoming slice-of-life film, *Little Thomas*, where he has been cast opposite Rasika Dugal. Directed by National Award-winning director Kaushal Oza, the movie delves into the life of a family that runs a small bakery in Goa.

"The journey of the family is traced through the eyes of a little boy, Thomas. I play his father in the film. The child within me connected with the story," shares Devaiah.

For Devaiah, the film brought back several memories from his childhood. Since he had no siblings, he would spend a lot of time on his own

For him, the film brought back several memories from his childhood. Since he had no siblings, he would spend a lot of time on his own. "I would also believe that my father, an engineer, was capable of building me a robot who would end up being my best friend," he laughs.

Devaiah's upcoming work includes *Ulajh*, a film where he stars opposite Janhvi Kapoor, and an eight-part series called *Bad Cop*. When choosing roles, Devaiah steers clear of those that are too similar to his personality, as they don't give him anything new to explore. "It's all about being honest with myself. I am a person who is intrigued by something he is not. For instance, I am not a villain, I haven't killed anyone. With acting, you get an opportunity to pretend to be someone else you are not," he says.

There are many admirers of his craft—with both critics and viewers raving about his range of characters. However, Devaiah is modest about his acting chops—he believes it's his imagination that has always guided him.

Of course, the rise of OTT can't be ignored; it has led to greater acceptance of 'character actors' by audiences. "Even before OTT, there were many filmmakers who wanted to make stories with me, but the business model of a theatrical release is so difficult. It requires money, knowledge and guts, especially with small or medium-budget films," says Devaiah.



Fortunately, streaming platforms have empowered storytellers who want to make certain kinds of movies, which would otherwise never see the light of the day as feature films. "When a shift like this happens, actors like me get opportunities. Movie stardom is still paramount. But it's an advantage that I can work in both mediums," he concludes. ■

–Geetika Sachdev